

Ajay Jadeja: India should return with a series win from Australia; we are well equipped

Former India captain Ajay Jadeja believes Rohit Sharma's team has **nothing to lose** and everything to gain in Australia, following their 0-3 Test series defeat to New Zealand at home.

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Ajay Jadeja played 15 Test matches for India from 1992 to 2000, amassing 576 runs with an average of 26.18, including four half-centuries and a top score of 96. His ODI career, however, truly showcased his talent, as he represented India in 196 matches, scoring 5,359 runs at an impressive average of 37.47, with six centuries and 30 half-centuries to his name.

In a conversation with senior sports journalist Vijay Lokapally at the Sportstar Sports Conclave – Focus Rajasthan, Jadeja shares his experience coaching Afghanistan, highlights from his playing career, and India's prospects in the upcoming Border-Gavaskar Trophy.

What was your experience like with the Afghanistan team, and do you see the potential in them to become world beaters?

I was privileged to have spent time with them. They started in Division Five of the World Cricket League about 14 years ago. No team has climbed the ladder as fast as they have. Now, you see smiling faces; you see these boys enjoying their sport. Whether it's Mohammad Nabi or Rashid Khan, they have convinced the world that these are good people who can gel with anybody. They were world-beaters at the ODI World Cup. They have taken that leap. For me, it was one of the best periods of my life — to be part of a team that was evolving and growing. They recently won the emerging trophy [ACC Emerging

Teams Asia Cup], and it won't be long before they become champions.

What's the most cherished memory from your playing career?

If you're a batter, you only feel truly satisfied when you score a hundred. The first time I scored a hundred for India, against the West Indies [in 1994] — and back then, the West Indies was a formidable side — remains special. That moment gave me assurance, even if I had doubts, that yes, this is what I had been

dreaming of. It's similar to winning a medal at the Olympics. Sure, getting picked for the first time feels great, but that's just the beginning. The first moment I truly felt happy was when I scored that hundred in Cuttack. Some moments stay with you forever. Like when I was bowled by Ronny Irani — I remember thinking, if you can't handle Irani, you can't play Test cricket. That

day, I closed the chapter on Test cricket for myself. But in One-Day Internationals, that hundred [against West Indies] has always stayed with me.

